

the camera contains when it produces either a still or moving image. Digital cameras scan horizontal lines of pixels that produce an image for the eye. By increasing the number of lines of pixels, the pixel density is much greater, which creates a much sharper and clearer image.

In order to qualify as a standard high-definition video camera, a product must be '720,' which means there are 720 horizontal lines of pixels and 1280 vertical lines. A full HD camera will have 1080 horizontal lines and 1920 vertical ones, which is why there is such a buzz around '1080' technology—it is the highest resolution available in HD at the moment creating the clearest images. This not only enables users capture brilliant stills and movies but also ensures that the print of the captured photograph or video is close to being real.

Now that sharing pictures has become as important as taking pictures, what are the sharing features being included in new cameras?

These days cameras are coming with a 'Share' button that allows uploading of pictures on numerous social networking sites such as Facebook, Flickr and even YouTube. This feature enables instant sharing of pictures from the computer instantly.

What is the pixel count of the latest cameras? How many does one really need?

EOS-1Ds Mark III, the latest camera by Canon, has 21.1 megapixels. However, megapixel is not the most important

thing in cameras. There are three factors to be considered for deciding a camera: optical technology, engine and sensor.

What are ultra-zoom cameras? Their advantages and disadvantages?

Cameras with long-zoom lenses are called 'ultra-zoom.' These have always been popular with digital camera enthusiasts. Most consumer digital cameras max out at 3x optical zoom with some at 4x optical zoom. But we are now seeing more and more cameras with 10x to 12x optical zoom.

An ultra-zoom camera is most useful in concerts, sports, nature and spy photography, enabling you to capture details from a distance. In these instances, the bigger the optical zoom, the better.

Talking of disadvantages, it is very difficult to handhold a camera above 6x optical zoom without suffering from camera shake. This results in blurred pictures. Some cameras more or less solve this problem with image stabilisation feature incorporated either in the lens or the image sensor.

Also, to include good zoom in consumer digital cameras, some compromises have to be made, one of them being the size of the image sensor used. The smaller the image sensor, the smaller, and therefore the cheaper, the lens. The problem with a small image sensor, however, is that noise is usually worse than with larger image sensors. But great strides in image sensor technology have been made in the last few years and the image quality at the lowest ISO is anywhere from good to excellent. ●

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